

The DIY Deck Building Checklist.

Updated July 2026 · hakadecks.com/diy-deck-building-checklist

Building it yourself? Respect. This is the order we run every job in — skip a step and it usually costs a weekend (or an inspection). Pin it to the garage wall.

01 Plan & budget

- ☐ Measure the space and sketch the footprint
- ☐ Pick decking material and railing style
- ☐ Price it out (see our Deck Cost Guide for a ballpark)
- ☐ Get HOA approval if you have one

02 Permit

- ☐ Draw the site plan with setbacks
- ☐ Draw the framing plan — footings, beams, joists, ledger
- ☐ Submit to your city; wait for approval before buying lumber
- ☐ Post the permit where inspectors can see it

03 Footings & posts

- ☐ Call 811 utility locates (free, required, 2–3 business days)
- ☐ Lay out post locations with batter boards and string
- ☐ Dig footings below frost line — 30–36" on the Front Range
- ☐ Pass the footing inspection BEFORE pouring concrete
- ☐ Set posts plumb and brace them

04 Framing

- ☐ Flash and bolt the ledger — most deck failures start here
- ☐ Set beams and hang joists (16" on center, typically)
- ☐ Block between joists; add stair stringers
- ☐ Pass the rough framing inspection

05 Decking & railing

- ☐ Run deck boards with consistent gaps (hidden fasteners for composite)
- ☐ Install railing posts, then panels — 36" min height, gaps under 4"
- ☐ Build stair treads and handrail
- ☐ Trim fascia and skirting

06 Finish

- ☐ Pass final inspection
- ☐ Seal or oil (wood only) once boards dry out
- ☐ Furniture, lights, first barbecue

In over your head at any step? No judgment — we take over half-finished decks more often than you'd think. The framing inspection is the usual breaking point. 720-589-5680.